

Computer Bureau Opened

New Zealand was seeing the beginnings of a new computer age, the Minister of Finance (Mr Lake) said in Christchurch on Wednesday.

He told a gathering of 150 businessmen attending the opening of Computer Bureau, Ltd., that the machines if properly used, could enable more work to be done with much less labour.

But this did not mean that people would be put out of work by the computers. If anything, some people would have to be retained to do other kinds of work.

Like all new scientific advances, computers could be used for good or evil, the Minister said. Men were still searching for the wisdom to use things for good. Mr Lake urged businessmen in Christchurch to support the enterprise which had set up the computer.

First Independent

It was the first to be set up in New Zealand independently and would relieve the Government of a good deal of pressure.

The computer is owned jointly by several Christchurch business organisations and is available for use by others.

The electronic machinery cost £120,000 and is housed in an air-conditioned dust-free room in a building in Chester street.

Its primary purposes for businessmen are calculating payrolls, preparing monthly statements and paying suppliers.

However, the main advantages of the computer are its ability to supply extra information more quickly and at no extra cost.

The chairman of directors of Computer Bureau, Ltd. (Mr E. A. Crothall) said there was a wrong idea abroad that the installation of a computer would magically resolve all the problems of its user.

He said the bureau had been set up in Christchurch to give industry and commerce faster and more penetrating control of operations.

Retailers, building manufacturers, local bodies, insurance companies were now using the computer.

"We are undertaking work for Lincoln College, the University of Canterbury and the D.S.I.R.," he said.

The original decision to buy a computer had been made after two firms of public accountants had investigated the requirements of a computer bureau in Christchurch in view of the impending change to decimal currency.

The machine was set up in September and in spite of minor teething troubles the installation had been successful.

"We were undertaking revenue-earning projects within hours after installation and are now running six major computer systems.

"We are adding these at the rate of one a month," he said.

Computer Bureau Opened

Using This Item

Stuff Ltd is the copyright owner for the Press. You can reproduce in-copyright material from this newspaper for non-commercial use under a [Creative Commons BY-NC-SA 3.0 New Zealand licence](#). This newspaper is not available for commercial use without the consent of Stuff Ltd. For advice on reproduction of out-of-copyright material from this newspaper, please refer to the [Copyright guide](#).

Acknowledgements

This newspaper was digitised in partnership with Christchurch City Libraries.